

*Sixty-ninth session of the Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space
Vienna, (10 – 18 June 2026)*

**STATEMENT BY AARTI HOLLA-MAINI
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Chair, Excellencies, distinguished delegates,

On behalf of Deputy Director Driss El Hadani and I, it is my pleasure to welcome all of you to the 69th session of the Committee on the Peaceful Uses of Outer Space. My congratulations to the elected Bureau for 2026-2027, and a special welcome to the six newest members of COPUOS: Cote D'Ivoire, The Gambia, Honduras, the Maldives, Malta, and Zimbabwe. Distinguished delegates, in presenting the UNOOSA strategy to you back in February of 2024, I noted the need to ensure that all UN Member States have a voice in this esteemed forum. Accordingly, you have seen new applications being received year-on-year and I am pleased to note the new applications received for this session from the Bahamas, Kyrgyzstan, Serbia, and Uganda, bringing the total number of new member applications since our arrival in 2023 to 12. We will continue our efforts to further increase the membership of COPUOS.

Over the same time period, the Committee has also significantly advanced its work. Yesterday during the Annual General Meeting of the Space Data Association, a permanent observer to this Committee, satellite operators, who once took very little interest in this body, commented that "COPUOS is clearly the place to be". Distinguished delegates this is a testimony to your achievements in the last two years.

This Committee continues to make steady progress on space resources, space situational awareness, information-sharing, and lunar coordination. This work directly responds to urgent current and future operational priorities, while also being essential to preserving the peaceful uses of outer space. It must continue to progress with the same momentum that we have seen during the last twelve months.

This is why UNOOSA supports the chairmanship of Italy in its efforts to secure a decision to hold UNISPACE IV in 2027. UNISPACE IV will help to supercharge the workstreams of the Committee; to focus all our minds on timely outcomes that are critical for the space community; *and* will elevate both COPUOS and UNOOSA, reminding the international community that this is *the* body and *the* Office that assures space for the 21st century and generations to come. Distinguished delegates, during the 2025 session, this Committee was positive towards organising a UNISPACE IV, but not enough to take a definite decision. Consultations since then have revealed a need for greater clarity around deliverables and funding. Given the visible progress on multiple workstreams, UNISPACE IV presents you with a unique opportunity to capitalise on this progress and secure outcomes backed by much needed high-level political support. Concerning funding, UNOOSA is confident that a decision to convene UNISPACE IV can be successfully operationalized through dedicated extrabudgetary contributions. I therefore thank Austria, as host country, for providing a leading example by contributing €400,000 towards the organisation of a UNISPACE IV in 2027, and I thank Italy for providing a Junior Professional Officer to the Office.

Distinguished delegates, in addition to providing you with trusted Secretariat services, this Office is operating at a strategic level to make sure that space technology, UNOOSA, and COPUOS all play their rightful role on the global stage. Our work is proactive *and* responsive to the diverse demands placed upon us.

Being a gateway between the increasing capabilities of space and the needs of member States, we can clearly see the urgent need to bridge the gap between demand and supply. Valuable data, for example, from Copernicus or Landsat satellites, is often available at little or no cost but the capacity and knowledge to use it is lacking. Multiple partners wish to offer more opportunities to developing countries to launch payloads into space through UNOOSA's Access2Space for All programme – again we see the supply and the demand, but we lack the capacity to bridge it.

Despite our limited resources, UNOOSA nonetheless continues to deliver very relevant impact – allow me share some examples:

Our UN-SPIDER programme is now a recognised operational partner within the UN humanitarian system in collaboration with UN OCHA.

Next week, together with the Commonwealth Secretariat and industry, we will launch the Space4Resilience initiative to support Small Island Developing States in building resilience in the face of sea level rise, leveraging our space and AI-powered digital twin solutions.

We have developed a Space Solutions Gateway with over 1,000 solutions and needs in its beta platform that have the potential to drive the uptake of space applications in the service of member State needs. This valuable tool will also require resources for maintenance.

El Salvador and Thailand are the latest winners under UNOOSA's Access to Space4All initiative and will deploy satellites from the Japanese module of the International Space Station.

We continue to service key international mechanisms for information-sharing and cooperation, which find their roots in UNISPACE III: the International Committee on Global Navigation Satellite Systems which is currently working on lunar positioning, navigation, and timing to support safe lunar missions. The International Asteroid Warning Network (IAWN) and the Space Mission Planning Advisory Group (SMPAG) which will launch a hypothetical asteroid impact exercise this August and which are spearheading the RAMSES mission to study asteroid Apophis in 2029.

To be more effective in responding to member State requests, we have established a dedicated Space Sustainability Section that will focus on implementation support and advisory services for member States on space law and policy, space traffic coordination, and space sustainability more generally.

We are also stepping up to provide critical tools to support safe space operations in line with discussions within the Expert Group on Space Situational Awareness. To enable coordination of in-orbit operational activities under LTS Guideline B1, we have created a UN Satellite Operator Contact Hub to facilitate the exchange of point of contact details for satellite operators. This tool will require resources to maintain going forward, but it is essential for emergency coordination between operators to avoid collisions and the potential loss of valuable space assets that today comprise critical infrastructure.

I invite you to review our 2025 Annual Report, "Pulling Back the Curtain," for more information on these activities and more.

Distinguished Delegates, many of the vital initiatives I have highlighted are entirely dependent on extra-budgetary contributions. While we are grateful to those member States who make so many of these achievements possible, we cannot deliver the benefits of today and secure the space environment of tomorrow on precarious balance sheets driven by unstable and short-term funding.

While space activities and related regulatory issues have dramatically scaled up, our resources continue to be disproportionately inadequate. Let me give you one example. In 2022, a time when forecasts projected 3,300 operational satellites in orbit by 2026, member States approved a P3 position for registration. In reality, 27,000 satellites have been launched and around 16,000 of them are operational today, a far cry from the predicted 3,300! Conservative projections now point to 100,000 satellites in orbit by 2030, while less conservative ones suggest several hundred thousand, and possibly even a million across multiple mega-constellations. You saved this one position from the latest budget cuts but even with it, we will still be far behind what we need to address the current and future volumes of space object registrations. I don't need to remind you that this is a fundamental Treaty obligation.

This lack of resources is not just a financial issue: it has real implications on our ability to deliver critical functions for the safety and sustainability of space activities. In 2025, we received more than 2,600 registration requests. Already by end-April 2026, we had received more than 2,400 – in just four months, and we are well on course to reach between 7,000 and 7,500 this year alone. This has generated a processing backlog currently standing at four months and, without additional resources, it will increase to 12 months by 2030 and even exceed a year if constellations deploy faster.

This backlog creates legal and operational risks for Member States. The lack of registration undermines crucial transparency obligations; it complicates liability attribution in the event of a collision. No registration also complicates the identification of space debris, at a time in which every year, more and more Member States request UNOOSA assistance when debris lands on their territory, a trend that *will* accelerate as congestion increases.

Further, as space activities increase in number and complexity, so does the need for our involvement in several areas required to implement our already vast mandate and I want to give you three concrete examples. While I believe you will understand how detrimental it would be to both UNOOSA and COPUOS if we did not engage in these processes, I hope you also realize that responsibility on us to deliver despite the absence of appropriate resources stretches us incredibly thin, and we are coming dangerously close to breaking point.

The first example is due to the dramatically rising cadence of space launches, which is causing the aviation community to become increasingly unsettled as airspace operations are more frequently disrupted. ICAO, the International Civil Aviation Authority, brought these concerns to UNOOSA with the request to cooperate to ensure a safe and balanced coexistence between aviation and space activities. ICAO has established a Task Force to examine this issue, and UNOOSA has been requested by multiple space regulators to participate in it and ensure that space interests are protected. The first meeting of this Task Force will take place next week on Tuesday and Wednesday here at the VIC, and we welcome delegates to attend if they wish to observe the proceedings.

The second example concerns the increasing number of space object reentries and the potential chemical changes on the various layers of the atmosphere, which is causing concern within the environmental community and Member State delegations engaging with the UN Environmental Programme (UNEP). UNEP brought these concerns to UNOOSA given our expertise and mandate, and together we hosted a small workshop to better inform ourselves around these emerging issues. We concluded that this is an area requiring further studies around which we will further cooperate.

The third example comes from overlaps and grey areas in mandates across Geneva and Vienna. Specifically, during 2025 and again in 2026, UNOOSA has been requested by numerous organisations including UNIDIR, UNODA, and various regional organisations, to brief member State delegations in Geneva on developments in the Committee. This has contributed to breaking down silos, promoting transparency, and even increased COPUOS membership applications. UNOOSA also continues to contribute to the work of ITU-R Working Party 4A dealing with aspects of satellite services to sensitise telecoms regulators to COPUOS' work, of which they are largely unaware. You will appreciate how critical this engagement is to safeguard the mandate of COPUOS concerning disposal and deorbit of space objects.

Finally, responding to requests of various space agencies, UNOOSA also became a founding member of the Space4Ocean Alliance launched at the 3rd UN Ocean Conference in 2025. The Alliance convenes over 31 space-related entities including 16 space agencies and works to systematically embed the use of space-based solutions for marine and coastal challenges. In its role as Chair, UNOOSA has fostered connections with the UN Ocean Decade and UN-Oceans – the UN inter-agency coordination mechanism. UNOOSA will assume the Secretariat of the Alliance during its Global Steering Committee meeting taking place later this week and interested member States are invited to attend an open session with industry on the morning of the 12th June in M6.

Distinguished Delegates, let me be frank: the time to act is now and UNOOSA is stepping up. But when UNOOSA is asked to deliver more than what our resources allow; and when issues compel us to go above and beyond in order to preserve your mandate in this Committee and our very existence; this puts UNOOSA in an impossible situation, over which you the Member States, ultimately have full control. Whether UNOOSA makes it or breaks up trying is entirely in your hands, and I urge you to take this responsibility seriously and translate your words of support into meaningful action.

UNOOSA is committed; highly efficient; and incredibly impactful for a staff of only 30 people. When I look at my Office, I cannot possibly conceive what more we can do. Either our resources grow to match our mandate and responsibilities, or it will be humanly impossible for us to keep delivering on them and support you in delivering on yours. I therefore urge all of you in this Committee, in your capitals, and with your colleagues in New York, to ensure that the work you value here in Vienna is matched by the means to sustain it.

Thank you.